EXECUTIVE GUIDE TO PERSONAL GROWTH

Leverage your personality traits to grow as a person and create your desired future

16Personalities

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Introduction

Why Personal Growth Matters to Executives

For Executives, the bedrock of a healthy life is a sense of order, tradition, and stability. Like other members of the Sentinel Role group, they feel a strong need to belong – whether to a family, a community, or some other social group. Born leaders, they often step into positions of responsibility and authority to organize people and ensure that best practices are followed.

Thanks to the combination of Observant and Judging traits, these types live in a concrete world of facts, data, and clear-cut boundaries. They have a firm sense of right and wrong, and given their honest, direct nature, feel compelled to share these views. Driven by an inner sense of responsibility, Executives have a strong work ethic and tend to do everything in their power to fulfill their duties and deliver on their promises. Social mores and conventions matter to people with this personality type, informing the standards that they set for themselves and others. As a result, Executives often grow into "model citizens," serving as pillars of their communities.

The principles that guide Executives in their communities tend to also guide their personal growth journeys. They often rely on rules and order when making self-improvements, following a religion or perhaps the steps outlined in a self-help book for structure. However, Executives can have a perfectionistic streak and may struggle to find satisfaction with their personal progress.

Similarly, people with this personality type may find it hard to accept other people's differences and shortcomings. Given their firm convictions, Executives run the risk of imposing their values on others. When others don't meet their high standards, Executives won't hesitate to share their disapproval. They may express irritation or even wrath toward those who can't match their prodigious work ethic, attention to detail, or loyalty. Executives are willing to make personal sacrifices to meet their obligations, and it frustrates them when the people in their lives won't do the same.

Executives are comfortable leading – and, at times, correcting – others. But when they begin looking inward at their own character, they can identify and address their own weaknesses, paving the way for significant strides in their personal growth and emotional development. In this e-book, we'll discuss how Executives can harness their many strengths to kick-start their personal growth, as well as how they can move past the stumbling blocks, both internal and external, that inevitably arise along the way.

Curious about the traits that make up your personality type and the theory behind them? You can learn more here.

Motivation and Development

Executives who want to improve themselves have several resources to draw on. A need to fulfill their duty (however they see it) motivates them to carry out their work, whatever it may be. Dependability is another fundamental element of the Executive personality – they don't dodge personal accountability and want others to perceive them as people on whom they can rely. They believe that no one is above adhering to a certain set of standards, least of all themselves. It's this definition of fairness that they can use as the baseline for personal improvement.

Facets of Personal Growth

Executives can consider personal growth in five closely related, but distinct, areas. The first three relate to the internal development of self-regard, and the latter two are more about tactics to engage in more fulfilling lives.

Motivation

- **Self-esteem** speaks to how much Executives like themselves. Accepting both their flaws and strengths creates a base of internal appreciation that enables change motivated by desire instead of shame.
- **Self-respect** speaks to their sense of worth. People with this personality type value being a part of strong communities, and when they live their beliefs and values, a balanced sense of pride in who they are follows.
- **Self-confidence** is the energy source that moves Executives forward in life. When belief in their abilities is confirmed using their skills, Executives are driven to make steady progress.

Development

- **Self-evolution** describes processes of conscious growth that Executives take on to realize their potential. Knowing when to assess and expand themselves enhances their abilities and happiness.
- **Self-responsibility** is taking charge of their lives by accepting accountability for what they can do to improve things. Being conscious of their behavior and direction in life helps them guide their own progress, instead of letting fate dictate a path.

Attending to each of these five areas can promote successful, fulfilling lives, while a lack of attention can serve as a source of persistent difficulty. For example, when Executives feel a lack of self-esteem, they may engage in intellectually aggressive behaviors that compensate for their insecurity – not often a path to objective learning and growth.

Moving Forward

Conscious personal growth is about more than feeling obligated to change. When inspired, Executives seek new ways to be happier and more successful – including an independent and personal definition of success. The goal is to spur their inner drive with ideas, encouragement, and guidance for possible problems along the way.

In the following sections, we'll first examine Executives' characteristics in their most beneficial forms. Using these motivational components in "balanced" ways helps these types lead fulfilling, productive, and happy lives.

Next, we'll describe "unbalanced" tendencies that can emerge – departures from healthy, productive motivation strategies. We'll also explain some adverse effects that Executives may experience as a result.

Finally, we'll discuss what Executives can do to improve or "rebalance" each of the motivational components, and provide exercises, reflection, and actions to aid in personal growth and development.

Self-Esteem

Simply put, self-esteem is about liking who one is, rather than who one wants to be. While similar to self-respect in that it's a motivator, self-esteem is less about having an overarching sense of worth stemming from self-efficacy and more about a sense of satisfaction with who one is as a person. It asks the question, "Do I like myself because of the way I conduct my life and the way I express myself in the world?"

Balanced Self-Esteem

Doing Good by the Rules

Executives attain self-esteem through their positive drive to make

the world effective for themselves and those they care about. Unlike many who might see rules as somewhat arbitrary, these types sincerely believe that set standards are essential to the world being a better place. When safeguarding these standards, Executives see themselves as contributing to the well-being of themselves and others – a very admirable thing to do.

It wouldn't be accurate to say that these types demand unthinking obedience to these rules. The reverence that they have for rules comes from an in-depth knowledge of them, and the maturity to understand that impulses must be guided by reason – with a set of rules providing the reason that may otherwise be lacking. Rules are a restraint, and though restraints can be confining, they can also be freeing, if they free people from making adverse decisions that would only serve to limit them in the end. "Nothing good happens between midnight and daylight," Executive parents may reason, and therefore see curbing potentially problematic behavior with a curfew as a restriction that only frees their teenage children to pursue activities that ultimately contribute to their well-being.

Diligent Attention

These types strive to maintain standards and make sure that people do things as they should – "should" being their culture's established standard. Their need for self-esteem motivates Executives to oversee their work with careful attention to protocols and expectations, and to raise their families and live their private lives dedicated to upholding conventional principles for living.

As these types mature, their understanding of these principles typically develops as well. Young Executives may look for older role models who exemplify the traits that appeal to them – stability, integrity, achievement – and find commonality in a shared set of standards that they appear to hold. Reasoning that those who keep similar convictions achieve comparable success, Executives may pattern themselves after these exemplars. As time goes on, however, they're sure to see that where there are rules, there's division, and even the clearest rules must be interpreted. In deciding which interpretations of these rules to follow (or how to interpret the rules for themselves), Executives take the first steps in becoming masters of their destiny.

Unbalanced Self-Esteem

Doubling Down on Standards

When Executives see a disconnect between the standards that they hold for themselves and their actual adherence to them, their internal need for coherence may manifest externally in increasing demands for order in the behavior of those around them.

Unfortunately, this can awaken a zealous rigidity. As unbalanced self-esteem manifests itself in perfection, stiffness plays a similar role for Executives seeking self-esteem. They can take an asset and allow it to "overheat" to make up for what ground they believe is lost.

Being a stickler can be a good thing. It's admirable to get things reasonably right. Being too much of a stickler, however, can overwhelm people. This can result in attempts to remove any human element, like emotions, from Executives' endeavors. Executives might reason that eliminating such distractions as exhaustion and dissatisfaction in the pure pursuit of profitable goals isn't only good for them, but good for others as well. Unfortunately, different types of people have unique ideas about the qualities that contribute to their self-esteem. In such cases, Executives may simply come across as overbearing and domineering, rather than the noble companions and colleagues they could be otherwise.

The Dark Path of Surrender

Executives who pursue this rigidity to the point of misery and failure for themselves or others may surrender to a darker impulse: an "all or nothing" mindset. If trying too hard makes things ineffective, they may throw up their hands and declare that any degree of trying is simply useless.

While Executives certainly have a deserved reputation for being hardworking, even they have their limits, both physically and emotionally. If their time-honored tactics of planning, consensus-seeking, and follow-through fail, it's probable that their motivation may disappear along with any chance of success.

Rebalancing Self-Esteem

Time Is Precious (and Passing By)

When we don't like who we are, it's primarily because we don't like what we do. By focusing on concrete actions, Executives move beyond abstract virtues and into quantifiable values. It's hard to say, for instance, who among a group of people is the most honest, or the most reliable, or the most hardworking. But if these individuals were to explain where their time went – to whom, and for whose benefit – then a clearer picture would begin to emerge.

In the end, time is the most unrenewable – and therefore, most valuable – resource. When time is spent on things, or on people, it shows that they're valued by those who place their own irrevocable value within them. Executives who squander their time squander their worth, and it's often only when they see clearly where their time has gone that they can begin to recover the self-esteem that they expended on fruitless endeavors. To do this, Executives can try the following activity:

- Executives who want to reevaluate their self-image may find it helpful to make two lists – their "pros and cons," so to speak.
- On the first list, they can write down all the ways they add value to others' lives. Even at particularly low points, they're sure to find instance after instance where they have helped other people get where they're going in life – and where they continue to do so.
- To deal with any concerns they have with liking themselves, Executives can create a list of the ways their actions benefit others. Their effect on others may be direct and personal, but it's just as likely to be indirect and involve supporting a system. The methods don't matter; all that matters is, due to some action on their part, someone they value saw a gain.
- On the second list, Executives should list their "cons" – all the ways that they've failed those around them, subtracting value rather than adding it.
- Though less pleasant than the previous one, this list may be far more instructive, highlighting those areas where these types should most seek change. Not that change is always possible, or even desirable – sometimes the fault isn't with us, but with circumstances. Still,

Executives owe it to themselves and to the people around them to make a change if the fault does lie in their hands.

Help from Objective Others

After taking a personal inventory, it might be helpful to compare notes with a trusted acquaintance. The objectivity that comes from an outside perspective can be invaluable in helping Executives come to more realistic appraisals of their strengths and weaknesses. Objective others might be all too willing to add items to Executives' "pros" list, remembering the positive effects that might have escaped their notice. At the same time, truly objective others can be just as quick to burst the bubble of Executives who claim too much credit or ignore the unintended consequences of their decisions.

When looking at the second list – the "cons" – objective others might be even more valuable. Together, they can assess tactics, helping Executives escape any counterproductive ruts that they might have fallen into.

Self-Respect

Self-respect involves Executives finding value in themselves. When their self-respect is low, they feel that they lack purpose. With high self-respect, their sense of value is firmly intact, and they believe that they're living up to the high standards that they set for themselves. These standards are grounded in the written and unwritten rules of family, culture, nation, religion, profession, or other community-based expectations, and they guide Executives as they make their way in the world, giving them a rubric by which to measure themselves. The closer to the mark they see themselves, the more satisfaction these types feel, but it's a matter of perception: self-respect can be reflected in their external achievements, but, ultimately, it's an attitude that must come from within.

Balanced Self-Respect

Finding Purpose in Protocol

Executives have great respect for structure and organization, which they see as a way of bringing order to the chaos of life. In adhering to the laws of the land or the rules of a contract, they show their deference to the wisdom of something greater than themselves.

For these types, rules are meant to be obeyed, but only because following the rules is often the best approach. If there seems to be a flaw in the rules, Executives may question it, but only at the proper time, and through the proper channels. However, when in doubt, they're more likely to stick to the script than play the part of renegades.

Finding Satisfaction in Effort

Wise Executives soon discover that rules are something to aspire to more than something to realize. No one can follow any creed with absolute dedication, and these types must accept their fallibility. By the same token, Executives must accept that they can measure gains in life only according to the effort they've exerted, not in the gains themselves.

Every day, Executives wake up with the knowledge that for every success they have, failure is waiting just around the corner to take it away. Rather than paralyzing them, however, this knowledge energizes them to leap out of bed and start attacking problems. And, every night, they go to sleep satisfied not with the number of problems solved, but by the effort expended in solving them. Executives with balanced self-respect rest easy knowing that while they aren't always right, they try as hard as they can to get it right, every day.

Unbalanced Self-Respect

No Excuses

Even Executives realize that there are times when rules have extenuating circumstances, but those whose self-respect is unbalanced often have trouble seeing where these exceptions might apply. They may adopt a "no excuses" policy for themselves and others, but this attitude seldom proves as productive as it might seem.

The Effects on Others

Even the best-laid plans can go astray, but failure isn't an option for Executives whose self-respect is unbalanced, and they may refuse to settle for even an iota short of perfection. Such aggressive perfectionism can lead to burnout on their part as well as low morale – or even mutiny – on the part of those who suffer under their reign. Such Executives may

see these effects as simply the price to pay to gain results, no matter how incremental.

This perfectionism can take a personal toll as well, exhausting even these energetic types. As they chase impossible standards and drive others away in the process, they may find themselves alone, separated from people who would otherwise freshen their outlook and efforts. Executives suffering from unbalanced self-respect can sustain this for impressive amounts of time through sheer force of will, but their bodies and minds eventually give out. When it comes to self-worth, without balance, they risk losing everything for which they've fought.

Relentless Perfectionism

Executives who have become too driven to perfection may win a few allies who respect their unswerving dedication, but none ever truly live up to the impossible standards that they've set. While Executives may feel that those who can't live up to their unbalanced standards are simply not worth keeping around, people are more complex creatures than a simple unbending set of rules can dictate.

In some cases, individuals are indeed toxic, and Executives are wise to steer clear of them. But when these types become toxic themselves – demanding more than those around them can (or should) reasonably give – then these guardians of community may soon find themselves without communities to defend. Having lost the trust – the confidence – of the people whom they once claimed to serve (albeit in a leadership role), Executives may see their confidence erode. A leader is nothing when there's no one to follow.

Rebalancing Self-Respect

Good Enough

Perfectionism naturally simmers in the background of Executives' lives, with all their standards and rules to maintain. When their self-respect is out of balance, they may need to guard against allowing fastidiousness to take over. While it's hard for these types to embrace the idea that sometimes "good enough" is, indeed, good enough, finding ways to do so gives them a more balanced sense of self, and a more realistic understanding of their strengths and weaknesses.

The world is more forgiving than these stringent perfectionists allow themselves to imagine. Catastrophes happen – and, at times, we can avoid them. However, there's a difference between preparation and overpreparation, and smart Executives learn when to tell which is which. If they've taken all *reasonable* precautions (and not all *possible* precautions) when catastrophes strike, at least they can rest assured that they did their due diligence in preventing them.

Taking Breaks to Gain Perspective

The best cure for misconceptions is a dose of reality. Executives who despair that all their efforts may come to naught have only to look at other people to see that, while they may not have all their bases covered, they do cover more than most. Those who become too insulated in their bubble of responsibilities may soon lose touch with the obstacles that others must overcome to pursue their goals. Here are some steps that Executives can take to reacquaint themselves to life outside their busy agendas:

- A few minutes to touch base with an acquaintance or two is often all it takes for Executives to gain a newfound appreciation for their capabilities, which they can be too quick to take for granted.
- During these breaks, it's important for these types to listen to better understand those around them. Often, people express problems in ways that are difficult for Executives to relate to. They're bold and rational, but not everyone shares these traits. Emotional perspectives can leave Executives wondering why others don't just run through the facts, and issuing complaints without wanting solutions can be downright frustrating.
- By taking a step back to exercise the patience and clarity that they ask of others, Executives provide individuals with opportunities to make themselves heard and understood. Sometimes people need to get their feelings out before they're ready to address issues. When Executives exercise this skill, they find themselves more valued and admired by those around them, boosting their sense of self-respect.

Self-Confidence

Self-confidence concerns trusting one's abilities. When self-confidence is lacking, every decision is shrouded in doubt and hobbled by hesitation. Self-confident Executives, on the other hand, act swiftly and decisively. They know they aren't always right, but infallibility is an impossible standard. To be the best, they need not be perfect, only better than second best.

Balanced Self-Confidence

Confidence from Reliability

Reliability refers to how Executives see themselves as people who can always be called on as either a first resort or a last resort to do what must be done. They're ambitious, but only because of their self-image as the most capable defenders of everything they hold dear. In their minds, if they fall down on the job, there's no one else to do it, or do it nearly as well. Executives work hard to ensure that whenever they're called on, they're able to perform at their peak.

These types are team players, not lone wolves, however. They may seek leadership positions, but happily serve capable leaders themselves, and may even insist that, "Everyone has a boss." Even if Executives see themselves as their team's most valuable asset, they still recognize that five, ten, or a hundred folks working in coordination can often accomplish more in a short period of time than any one of them could in an entire lifetime. If they want to be perceived as reliable, it's because they want to have relationships with other reliable people whom they can trust, whether in business, romance, or simple friendship.

Pride in Achievement

Executives take pride in their accomplishments, which they see as merely the consequent rewards of living successful lives. Medals and trophies are concrete representations of the countless invisible hours of hard work athletes and other competitors sacrifice to be the best. In much the same way, the manicured lawns and well-kept automobiles of Executives tell the world that they're sacrificing, too – though they don't see it as a sacrifice, only their duty as productive members of society. Nice houses and cars aren't mere luxury goods for them, but

concrete ways of showing the world they work hard for what they have, and they spend their money with more prudence than extravagance.

After all, talk is cheap. People can claim to be caring spouses, supportive parents, or industrious workers all they want, but Executives have the goods to back up their claims: well-dressed families and well-kept homes are all the evidence they need of their efforts. Those with balanced self-confidence know their success is apparent, leaving them with no reason to restate the obvious by bragging about it.

Unbalanced Self-Confidence

Making Unreasonable Efforts

Executives who become too determined to prove their worth to others may begin to lose the ability to distinguish between reasonable efforts to fulfill their obligations, and heroic efforts that are out of proportion to the size of their original commitments. Their insecurities may also drive them to tear down the achievements of others, particularly if they appear more successful in some way: wealthier, more attractive, more content. In both cases, Executives with unbalanced self-confidence are looking elsewhere for reassurance, when it's instead their internal perception of themselves that's flawed.

Over Commitment

In most cases, Executives realize that their time is finite, and keep their schedules busy but manageable. But when these types feel their accomplishments don't match their self-image, they may compensate by sacrificing more time for others than they can truly spare. Those with unbalanced self-confidence may assume that they're more capable than they really are and promise more than they can reasonably deliver. Executives with multiple commitments may be forced by changing circumstances to re-prioritize, leading to broken promises and damaged trust on the part of all involved.

Little is more harmful to Executives' self-image than the inability to follow through on their commitments. They may attempt to shore up their self-confidence by being harder on themselves – taking on more responsibilities at the expense of losing precious free time. This vicious

cycle helps no one, as increasingly burned out Executives only become less and less capable of fulfilling even their original obligations, not to mention any new ones they take on.

Insecurity through Envy

These types pride themselves on their ability to do anything that needs to be done as well as, or better than, anyone else, so failures – even the most understandable ones – can make them uneasy. Executives who feel they aren't living up to their internal standards may compensate by minimizing the achievements of others to draw focus away from their own lack of success.

Professional setbacks may lead Executives with unbalanced self-confidence to cast aspersions on their coworkers or professional peers. They may claim that any advantages coworkers possess are due not to differences in ability or effort, but instead to favoritism or other extraneous political factors. This attitude doesn't only come into play at work, of course – Executives with shaken self-confidence may lash out at their romantic interests' exes or other potential partners, for instance. But the attitude in every case is the same – when their self-confidence is unbalanced, Executives see others' accomplishments as threatening because they always have the nagging thought, "What has this person done, that I have not, to achieve something that I want in life?"

Rebalancing Self-Confidence

Hard Work and Fair Play

For Executives, hard work and fair play are all it takes to succeed in life. When they perceive that peers – or worse still, younger individuals – are experiencing greater success, these types tend to reach one of two conclusions: either those people work harder, or they have hidden advantages. While there's often some truth in both conclusions, Executives who dwell too long on what others are doing are only ignoring their own unique contributions and strengths.

Managing Obligations

Little disturbs Executives' sense of self-confidence more than failing to live up to their obligations, which only becomes more likely as the

number their obligations increase. Although Executives are skilled at managing busy schedules, they tend to leave little space in them for themselves, and even less when they feel they must prove themselves. Here are some ideas these types can try to bring some balance back to their obligations:

- Thinking twice before taking on new obligations is always helpful, but in addition to being more protective of their time, Executives would do well to remember that obligations are a two-way street. The people who rely on them can be counted on in turn, and smart Executives know when to ask for favors, as well as when to repay them.
- Not that they should keep track of every good turn they do for others, or for every courtesy done for them, but Executives would be wise to have a general sense of the balance of obligations in their relationships. When they tip too heavily in someone's favor, it might be time to re-adjust.

Accounting for Individual Differences

When Executives look at successful contemporary role models, or those from their past, they're often quick to discount any inherent advantages that may have contributed to their success. After all, if certain things aren't under their control – such as circumstances of birth and upbringing – then there's no use dwelling on them. However, if it becomes apparent that someone has accomplished much more than these types have, their beliefs in the power of persistence, and integrity trumping luck and duplicity, are tested.

It can be tempting for Executives to try to ignore the disproportionate success of the fortunate and the wicked alike, perhaps by pointing out their flaws in unrelated areas, or by imagining the dire consequences that can befall them as soon as their luck runs out – or their lack of character catches up with them. These approaches only fuel the envy that's so damaging to Executives' self-confidence. Instead of looking at others, they should pay more attention to what separates them from others – such as the satisfaction they get from applying the principles of hard work and fair play in their everyday lives. There's always someone who has more, whether acquired fairly or not, but mature Executives

retain their self-confidence because it's predicated not on a belief in their own superiority, but in the knowledge that living according to their principles gives a life of satisfaction, even if success happens to elude them for the moment.

Self-Evolution

Self-evolution is the power that Executives possess to change as circumstances change around them. As much as they prize their steady, unswerving attitude toward life, they know that too much determination can lead to an unproductive rigidity. They may use tried-and-true methods, but they also continue to test them as time goes on, keeping only the ones that remain useful.

Balanced Self-Evolution

Strength through Continuity

The power of Executives comes from their mastery of tradition, and those whose self-evolution is balanced use this mastery of the past to solve the problems of the present. In looking at the past, they search for patterns of success, which they then seek to perpetuate into the future. The accumulated wisdom of the ages rests in the traditions that guide Executives' decisions, and those who balance their self-evolution respond to it as they would respond to the advice of older mentors: with a respectful ear, not blind obedience.

Conditions change, and sometimes methods must change with them. Executives have a broad view of tradition, seeing it as a living thing that, like themselves, grows, matures, and develops over time. They adjust, but they adjust for the better, and always with certain constants underpinning all they do.

Addition from Subtraction

While it's true that Executives prefer to use established methods, they continue to test them as time goes on, keeping only the ones that remain of use. If a method provides a suitable rate of return, then they use it unaltered. Even when a method begins to fall apart, Executives

prefer to change it as little as possible. Rather than throw out the entire rulebook, these types simply edit out the more troublesome rules.

By subtracting the weakest parts of a system, Executives add to its strength. But it's only by careful observation of where a system breaks down that they can determine where the weaknesses are. Executives know where to adjust, and what to leave unchanged.

Unbalanced Self-Evolution

The Challenge of Change

People with the Executive personality type view change with skepticism more than disdain. Tradition has the weight of iteration behind it – years, decades, or centuries of people who, repeatedly faced with similar problems, devised a method for solving them. Others could then successfully copy the method without alteration. Though changing circumstances may call for altered methods, Executives prefer to see the tested method fail before introducing an untested one, no matter how promising the latter might be. Indeed, even one failure may be written off as a failure of execution – human error – rather than a flaw in the method itself.

With balanced self-evolution, Executives can recognize the difference between a flawed method and a flawed execution. However, those with unbalanced self-evolution may simply repeat formerly successful behaviors, no matter how unsuccessful they now are.

Rebalancing Self-Evolution

Using Tradition as a Guide

Famed author W. Somerset Maugham once said, "Tradition is a guide and not a jailer." This aphorism can serve as a powerful insight for Executives. Using it as a guide, they won't diminish their respect for tradition, but they also won't enslave themselves to it, either. Here are some steps these types can take toward rebalancing their traditional approach:

- Accepting the inevitability of change can be the first step.
- Learning to blend the old with the new can help these types create a more balanced view.
- Spotting the difference between maintaining stability and being stubborn can also help them better navigate a changing world.

Self-talk and self-examination, such as, "Am I offering helpful insights into how things work, or am I just finding change difficult to handle?" and similar questions may help.

Self-Care Supports Taking Care of Business

A well-maintained machine functions better than one that's neglected, and Executives who take care of themselves are better at taking care of everything else. Self-care, then, isn't an indulgence, but an investment – the time that they spend on family vacations or long coffee breaks isn't wasted, but comes back to them in increasing dividends.

At times, these types can become so focused on fulfilling their obligations that they lose sight of the reasons that they do the things they do. Taking time to remind themselves of the inherent value of the things they cherish most – the communities that they draw their strength from – can renew their resolve at the times that test them most, allowing them to act as the bold, resilient leaders they are.

Self-Responsibility

Executives' sense of responsibility derives from their need to honor their rational approach to tradition and accepted principles. Their personal sense of responsibility and obligation to society can't be entirely separated – they take care of themselves when they take care of the world. Fulfilling their sense of responsibility can help them achieve healthy self-esteem, self-respect, and self-confidence.

Balanced Self-Responsibility

Seeing Things Through

For these types, self-responsibility refers to the need to fulfill the

obligations they've set for themselves. When Executives take on duties, their self-image becomes linked to their ability to see them through. While this principle is true of even small tasks – running an errand for a spouse, or picking up a friend at the airport – the overarching obligations that constitute their lives are what drive them from day to day. Whether at home or work, they seek security – and fulfilling obligations, for them, is an effort to cultivate it in their lives.

When they do their part to hold up their end of a deal, they gain assurance that others can feel compelled to do likewise. Those who can't be relied upon shouldn't expect to rely on others, either; this isn't only a watchful defense on Executives' part, but a proactive search for threats to squelch and opportunities to seize. These types aren't risk-averse, but risk-aware, and careful to ensure that any gambles they take are smart ones. They're willing to risk investments – of time, money, or feeling – if the rewards are promising and the odds are weighted heavily in their favor. Executives don't like to lose, but they know that to win, they must play: nothing ventured, nothing gained.

Masters of Organization and Standards

Organization comes naturally to Executives. They know what to do and who to call to make things happen smoothly, and tend to have all-encompassing resources they become familiar with and achieve mastery over. This helps them organize efficiently. At home, at work, and as parents, they're likely to have just as much of a command of resources.

Their widespread attention to detail isn't for its own sake, as Executives connect it to responsibility and accountability. Life for them is often a series of rubrics, arranged and linked to provide an organized, consistent path.

The Value of Persistence

These types enjoy the gifts of patience and focus. Valiant in their ability to endure hardships, they sometimes take on more onerous tasks than necessary simply because they know they can do them and gain more than they lose, whether regarding character building or more concrete rewards. The most mundane work is no problem for Executives if they

grasp its rational purpose, if it fits a paradigm they're familiar with, or if it's paired with a powerful sense of obligation.

Executives' persistence presents value in many ways. While they may not always find motivation from within, once engaged, they're finishers, and the idea of something left undone if they don't finish is a strong motivator. People with the Judging trait find satisfaction in chapters that are completed and closed. Being persistent enough to finish a task reinforces their sense of reliability and, consequently, their self-esteem.

Unbalanced Self-Responsibility

Growth occurs when Executives use their sense of responsibility and dedication to move forward in life. However, as with all good things, diligence can shift from a powerful tool to a demanding tyrant if not properly balanced against other considerations.

Too Little Self-Care

Executives build their self-responsibility upon their successful execution of personal obligations and upholding established standards. When they aren't feeling great about themselves or their lives, their sense of responsibility may go into overdrive as they search for a more positive sense of themselves. Instead of integrating self-care and rest into their plans, they may feel an urgency to go in the opposite direction, pushing themselves – and others – relentlessly.

At such times, these types may forget the softer side of dealing with people, including themselves, the side where gentle coaxing is more effective than harsh mandates. Executives aren't always in touch with their feelings. Those who are too driven to accomplish a task may appear unreasonable to people with other priorities or methods.

Even Executives, who tend to be stalwart, become stressed when tension from their overbearing attitude breaks down the morale, willingness, and effectiveness of the very people they depend on most. Such breakdowns can start vicious cycles where they're disappointed in their performance, feel stressed about it, and then go deeper into burnout. The personality type who always knows what to do can find itself without a solution.

Rebalancing Self-Responsibility

Making Realistic Assessments

Executives who find themselves suffering from taking on too much responsibility may need to assess who they are, what their duties are, and why they feel the need to push so hard. They also might want to decide if their relentless efforts are paying off or not. Working exceedingly hard may appear to be the right thing to do at times. But it can also exact a toll on individuals. Matching the cost to the benefit is essential.

These types typically choose action over ruminating over things. However, this go-to tactic may not be helpful when doing too much is the problem. Learning to prioritize activities that have proven to be important, and balancing them with downtime and relaxation, can make this tactic more responsible. Burnt-out shells of Executives are less effective than those who take the time to restore themselves. Asking, "Why?" instead of pursuing less considered action can help set clearer paths – especially when their need to feel responsible begins to "overheat" and results in an explosion of activity.

Managing Stress

Stress can be a good thing – like a heavy weight, the more it's handled, the stronger handlers become. But the dangers of handling too much stress are much the same as the risks of lifting too much weight: snapping under the pressure. And though Executives are often adept at handling stress, they have their limits, too. Extraverted Executives might find that stress relief is often less about finding a peaceful place in their lives as it is about getting frustrated energy out in healthy ways. Here are some ideas that can help:

- A night on the town with a few friends, or a pick-up ball game in the park, may be more effective than a quiet evening with a book or a lazy afternoon in a hammock – although of course, even Executives need rest sometimes.
- When they do need a more sedate outlet for stress relief, there are countless methods available, including deep breath meditation (in which someone sits still and focuses their entire, exclusive attention on the in and out of their breath), respectful life planning (in which

busy Executives identify reasonable timelines and priorities, rather than pushing for what could be done, an unreasonable long-term strategy), or simply planning in some time to relax with family and friends, or even alone.

- Everyone needs a break, including busy Executives who see themselves as indispensable. True, they often find themselves – or more accurately, intentionally place themselves – in positions of extreme responsibility that aren't so easily abdicated. Then it becomes an additional responsibility for them to find people who can take over so that the responsibility doesn't always have to fall squarely on these types, who may not complain, but inevitably suffer under the burden.
- This is true as well for unforeseen circumstances – all it takes is one power outage or faulty engine part to keep even the most diligent Executives from fulfilling an obligation.

Learning to turn off their phones and laptops occasionally can help Executives exercise responsibility for themselves by setting aside their responsibility for everyone else. If they've delegated wisely, they should have no trouble leaving their children in the care of capable babysitters, or their businesses in the care of capable administrators.

Final Words

Like a seedling poking its head through the soil in the early spring, growth rarely happens without something emerging from the comforts of the familiar. Personal growth takes effort, and it may require Executives to venture into new terrain that isn't always familiar or comfortable. Executives may be accustomed to living within traditional systems. However, systems have a way of swallowing up individual strengths, and people with this personality type, more than most, may have trouble maintaining their identity under pressures to conform. After all, they feel little intrinsic pleasure in doing things "just to be different," so in the absence of a compelling counterargument, Executives may find it easiest to go along with the crowd – at least superficially, until such a counterargument arises.

On certain issues, they may stand their ground no matter what. But when it comes to long-held rules and expectations, Executives may see compliance as a smart compromise. However, following community standards may, at times, conflict with personal growth. Executives who stretch themselves beyond social norms may discover a world of self-development that honors the personal needs and values that set them apart, strengthening their leadership skills by focusing first on *self*-leadership.

In these pages, we've outlined how Executives can work on their growth and development in multiple areas of their lives. Our hope is that these insights and strategies equip Executives with the tools needed to thrive in society without neglecting themselves in the process. When people with this personality prioritize their personal growth over external pressures and responsibilities, they can often achieve far more than they ever imagined.

So... What's Next?

You've reached the end of this book, but fear not – we've created many more resources for you. Here are a few that might capture your interest:

- Want more tests and insights to help you direct your personal growth journey? Explore our Personal Growth Specialized Tests.
- Looking to enhance your academic or professional life? Check out the *Executive Guide to Careers*.
- Feeling adrift when it comes to your romantic relationships, friendships, or relationships with your children? Our *Executive Guide to Relationships* may be just what you need.

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